

Rousettus aegyptiacus

Egyptian rousette



Length 5½–6½ in (14–16 cm)

Tail ½–¾ in (1.5–2 cm)

Weight 2½–3½ oz (80–100 g)

Location W. Asia, N. Africa (Egypt), W., E., and southern Africa

Social unit Group

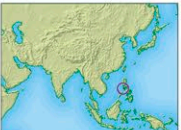
Status Least concern



Widespread and adaptable, these fruit- and leaf-eating bats are sometimes so common that they reach pest status and damage farm crops. They are also one of the fruit bat species to use the high-pitched “clicks” of echolocation. This means they can find their way around and roost in dark caves, rather than sleeping in trees like other fruit bats.

Styloctenium mindorensis

Mindoro stripe-faced fruit bat



Length 6–7 in (15–18 cm)

Tail None

Weight ¼–½ lb (150–210 g)

Location Philippines

Social unit Group

Status Data deficient



With its orange coat and white-striped face, this stunningly colored fruit bat was discovered in 2006 in lowland forest on Philippines’ Mindoro Island—following local rumors of its existence. It is found nowhere else though there is speculation that Western Australian aboriginal paintings depict this bat or a closely related species. Currently, the only other member of its genus is known with certainty from Sulawesi. Little is known about Mindoro’s stripe-faced fruit bat, and the species is threatened by deforestation and hunting.



smoky gray underparts

collar of yellow or buff fur most obvious in males

FUR-COVERED FOREARMS
The Egyptian rousette varies from dark brown to slate gray on the back, with lighter, smoky gray underparts. Unusually, its fur extends about halfway along each forearm.

Epomops franqueti

Franquet’s epauletted bat



Length 4¼–6 in (11–15 cm)

Tail None

Weight 3–3½ oz (85–100 g)

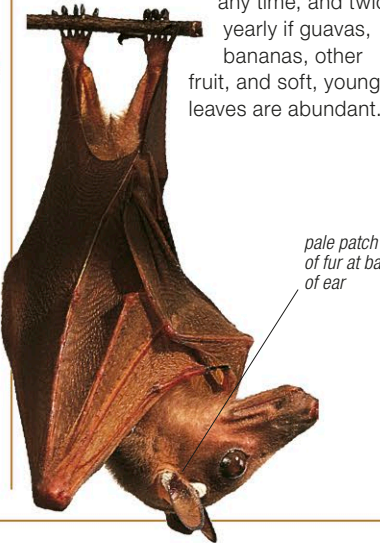
Location W. and C. Africa

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



At night, male Franquet’s epauletted bats make monotonous high-pitched whistling calls to attract females for mating. The male is slightly heavier than the female and has shoulder patches of long, pale hairs. This species breeds at any time, and twice yearly if guavas, bananas, other fruit, and soft, young leaves are abundant.



pale patch of fur at base of ear

Epomophorus wahlbergi

Wahlberg’s epauletted fruit bat



Length 4¾–6¼ in (12–15.5 cm)

Tail None

Weight 2½–4 oz (65–125 g)

Location E., C., and southern Africa

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern





In addition to white “epaulette” fur patches on the male’s shoulders, both sexes have 2 white patches at the base of each ear. These pale tufts may be disruptive camouflage, breaking up the bat’s outline when seen from below against dappled leaves. In the breeding season, the male’s distinctive call to attract females resembles a squeaky bicycle pump.

Pteropus rodricensis

Rodrigues flying fox



Length 14 in (35 cm)

Tail None

Weight 9–10 oz (250–275 g)

Location Indian Ocean (Rodriguez Island)

Social unit Group

Status Critically endangered



Formerly, the daytime roosts or “camps” of this flying fox contained more than 500 individuals. Due to habitat loss, through storm damage and human intervention, and also local hunting for food, the species currently numbers about 4,000 in the wild. Several centers, however, have established successful captive breeding programs. At night, the bats forage in dry woodland for fruit of various trees, such as tamarinds, rose-apples, mangoes, palms, and figs. Like many other fruit bats, they squeeze out the juices and soft pulp, rarely swallowing the harder parts. Observations in captivity show that each dominant male gathers a harem of up to 10 females, with which he roosts and mates. Subordinate and immature males tend to roost in another part of the camp.



hooklike foot claws permit roosting without muscle tension

brown wing membranes

brown fur

Rhynchonycteris naso

Proboscis bat



Length 1½–2 in (3.5–5 cm)

Tail ¾–1 in (1–1.5 cm)

Weight ⅙–⅞ oz (3–6 g)

Location Mexico to C. South America

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



Also called the sharp-nosed bat, this species has a long, pointed nose and streamlined appearance. It is a typical small, insectivorous bat, but shows unique roosting behavior as groups of 5–10 (rarely more than 40) rest by day in a line, nose-to-tail on a branch or wooden beam. One adult male may dominate the group and may defend their feeding area—a nearby patch of water where they catch small insects.



white stripes on back

Tapophous mauritanicus

Mauritian tomb bat



Length 2¼–3½ in (7.5–9.5 cm)

Tail ¾–1¼ in (2–3 cm)

Weight ⅙–1⅙ oz (15–30 g)

Location W., C., E., and southern Africa, Madagascar

Social unit Group

Status Least concern





A member of the sheath-tailed group, the Mauritian tomb bat is known across Africa for its wide range of clicks, squeaks, and other noises just audible to some humans. It also makes ultrasonic sounds for echolocation. This active bat is watchful as it roosts by day in the open on tree trunks and walls, including town buildings. It hunts in clearings, especially over water, for flying insects. The back is grizzled brown-black; the underparts and wings are white.